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United States Patent

12408913

Kind Code

B2

Date of Patent

September 09, 2025

Inventor(s)

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Magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet, a bifurcated suture, and a cartridge tube

Abstract

A magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet, a bifurcated suture, and a cartridge tube is disclosed. The bifurcated suture extends from the suture magnet and forms a suture loop. The cartridge tube comprises a cartridge tube proximal end, a cartridge tube distal end, and a cartridge tube wall extending therebetween. The cartridge tube has a cartridge tube proximal opening at the cartridge tube proximal end, a cartridge tube distal opening at the cartridge tube distal end, and a cartridge tube lumen extending from the cartridge tube proximal opening to the cartridge tube distal opening. The suture loop traverses the cartridge tube lumen based on having been inserted through the cartridge tube distal opening. The suture magnet is disposed outside of the cartridge tube lumen adjacent the cartridge tube distal opening.

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Appl. No.: 18/501145

Filed: November 03, 2023

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier

US 20240057998 A1

Publication Date

Feb. 22, 2024

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17995779 US 11839373 20231212 WO PCT/US2022/029627
20220517 child-doc US 18501145
us-provisional-application US 63268596 20220225
us-provisional-application US 63189511 20210517

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **A61B17/062** (20060101); **A61B17/04** (20060101); **A61B17/06** (20060101); A61B17/00 (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **A61B17/06166** (20130101); **A61B17/0469** (20130101); **A61B17/06004** (20130101); A61B2017/00349 (20130101); A61B2017/00867 (20130101); A61B2017/00876 (20130101)

Field of Classification Search

CPC: A61B (17/0469); A61B (17/0482); A61B (17/0485); A61B (17/06166); A61B (17/062); A61B (17/0625); A61B (2017/06004); A61B (2017/00867); A61B (2017/00349); A61B (2017/047)

USPC: 606/139; 606/144; 606/145; 606/146; 606/147; 606/148; 606/149; 606/150

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 17/995,779, filed Oct. 7, 2022, now U.S. Pat. No. 11,839,373, which is a national stage application of International Appl. PCT/US2022/029627, filed May 17, 2022, and which claims the benefit of U.S. Provisional Application No. 63/268,596, filed Feb. 25, 2022, and U.S. Provisional Application No. 63/189,511, filed May 17, 2021, all of which are hereby incorporated by reference.

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) The invention relates to a magnet-assisted suture grasper for grasping a magnetic suture, and more particularly to a magnet-assisted suture grasper for grasping a magnetic suture comprising a suture retrieval needle, a retriever body, a grasper wire, a grasper arm, and a grasper magnet.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(2) Suture passing is required in many surgical procedures. A suture passer is a surgical instrument

which provides a means of delivery and/or retrieval of a suture through some bodily tissue. There are many existing instruments on the market which utilize a mechanical solution to secure a suture for passing.

(3) Increasingly, minimally invasive techniques are being employed over open surgery due to reduction in risk, faster recovery time, and generally better cosmesis. Minimally invasive techniques typically make use of a scope and specialized tools that can be inserted through existing openings of a patient (e.g., via endoscope, colonoscope, etc.) or artificially created openings of the patient (e.g., via laparoscope, arthroscope, etc.) to gain access to the targeted intracorporeal working space.

(4) Working with indirect visualization of surgical instruments through a scope presents a significant technical challenge to the use of suture passers for retrieval. Retrieving a suture using a typical suture passer requires precise positioning and careful manipulation of the suture passer to position one or more grasping elements of the suture passer around the suture. The suture passer must be held relatively steady in position while the grasping elements are closed about the suture, capturing the suture and holding it firmly so it can be retrieved. Skillful manipulation in this manner is hampered by the fact that most scopes employ a single camera and present a two-dimensional image to the suture passer operator and thus do not provide stereoscopic imaging. The lack of stereoscopic imaging hampers the operator's ability to perceive depth, which increases the level of difficulty associated with precisely positioning the grasping elements around the suture. While three-dimensional imaging systems exist, they are expensive and to date remain relatively rare in the field.

(5) Most existing suture passer designs utilize a multi-arm design, where two or more arms are opened and brought around a suture, then closed around the suture to capture it. The arms may be separate, creating a pincer-style grasper with jaws to grasp a suture, or they may be connected, forming a snare-type grasper forming an eye through which a suture can be threaded.

(6) Unfortunately, regardless of the arm design, these devices require precise positioning to get the jaws of the grasper around the suture, or to thread the suture through the eye of the snare before the suture can be captured. As noted, this is difficult under indirect visualization because camera systems for indirect visualization are typically non-stereoscopic. Without a three-dimensional image, a surgeon must rely on visual cues to judge the instrument position and depth, which makes it difficult to get the instrument positioned properly. Once the instrument is in position, the surgeon then needs to hold the instrument and the suture very steady while attempting to close the grasper around the suture. The long moment arm created by the length of the instrument magnifies even very minor movements, so that a small movement can bring the two components out of alignment. Failed attempts at grasping a suture can extend procedure times and lead to frustration in the operating room.

(7) A magnetic U-stitch suturing device intended to address these difficulties has been disclosed in U.S. Pat. No. 10,245,021. The magnetic U-stitch suturing device is made of two hypodermic needles allowing one or more sutures, at the same time, and a retrieval probe to be advanced into a cavity, such as a stomach cavity, of a patient. The one or more sutures can be magnetic sutures, each including a suture magnet, as described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667. Both the suture and retrieval probe comprise magnets of opposite polarities on their leading ends. Thus, after the suture and retrieval probe are inside the stomach cavity, the suture and retrieval probe may mate and the suture may be transferred from one hypodermic needle to the other using magnetic attraction. In doing so, the suture forms a loop through the stomach. Once removed, this loop, having two ends that are positioned outside the patient's body, can be pulled tight in order to pull the stomach wall closer to the surface of the patient's body. With the stomach wall close to the surface of the patient's body, it is easier to insert a gastrostomy device.

(8) Unfortunately, certain procedures, such as inguinal hernia repair through high ligation of the patent processus vaginalis, require passing of a suture in a space, e.g., a peritoneal cavity, that is not

sufficiently large to permit advancement of the two hypodermic needles of the magnetic U-stitch suturing device simultaneously.

(9) Other suture instruments and/or sutures including magnets also have been disclosed. For example, U.S. Pat. No. 10,299,786 discloses a suture insertion device utilizing small gauge needles for threading one or more sutures through subcutaneous tissue. The suture insertion device can include a magnetic capture mechanism for contacting a magnetically attractive strand in transverse alignment. U.S. Pat. Nos. 6,719,765 and 9,770,238 disclose instruments for passing a medical implement through tissue with magnetic forces. U.S. Pat. No. 8,702,753 and U.S. Pub. No. 2008/0243148 disclose sutures to which magnetic anchors are attached. U.S. Pub. No. 2020/0360017 discloses a suturing apparatus in which a suture thread may be automatically passed between a needle and a transfer tube. The suturing apparatus can include electromagnetic coils to engage and release a suture from the system. U.S. Pub. No. 2020/0214695 discloses a suturing system including a forceps arm and a suture that may be magnetic to thus engage with each other. U.S. Pub. No. 2022/0104802 discloses a suturing system including a rod having a magnetic tube extending from an end thereof and a magnetic needle having an end attracted into the tube to magnetically engage therewith. U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667 discloses a magnetic suture that has a ferrule with a tapered region in which a knotted suture is provided and secured with an adhesive and a straight region in which a magnet is provided.

(10) Improved suture passers that reduce the technical difficulty associated with capturing and retrieving sutures under indirect non-stereoscopic visualization are needed.

BRIEF SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(11) A magnet-assisted suture grasper for grasping a magnetic suture is disclosed. The magnet-assisted suture grasper comprises: (a) a suture retrieval needle comprising a proximal end, a distal end, and a needle body extending therebetween, the needle body defining a needle body axis between the proximal and distal ends of the suture retrieval needle, the needle body having a proximal hole, a distal hole, and a needle lumen extending therebetween along the needle body axis; (b) a retriever body disposed within the needle lumen and translatable therein along the needle body axis; (c) a grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; (d) a grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the grasper arm extending from the distal end of the grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between a first position and a second position; and (e) a grasper magnet being disposed adjacent the proximal-to-intermediate portion of the grasper arm, the magnet-assisted suture grasper sequestering the grasper magnet within the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the first position and exposing the grasper magnet from the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the second position. The distal end of the grasper arm extends further distally than the grasper magnet. Translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the first position to the second position, thereby exposing the grasper magnet and allowing contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto. Translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a second direction opposite the first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the second position to the first position, thereby sequestering the grasper magnet and grasping the magnetic suture within the needle lumen.

(12) In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle is a hypodermic needle.

(13) In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle is straight, the needle body axis thereby being straight.

(14) In some embodiments the suture retrieval needle is curved, the needle body axis thereby being curved.

(15) In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle has a sharp tip.

(16) In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle further comprises a hub.

(17) In some embodiments, the retriever body and the grasper wire are more flexible than the

needle body.

(18) In some embodiments, the retriever body comprises a proximal end, a distal end, and a retriever tube extending therebetween, the retriever tube defining a retriever tube axis between the proximal and distal ends of the retriever body, the retriever tube having a proximal hole, a distal hole, and a retriever tube lumen extending therebetween along the retriever tube axis; and the proximal hole of the retriever tube is in fluid communication with the distal hole of the needle body through the retriever tube lumen and the needle lumen.

(19) In some embodiments, the grasper arm is integral to the grasper wire.

(20) In some embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises a magnet wire having a proximal end and a distal end, wherein the proximal end of the magnet wire is fixedly disposed within the retriever body and the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the distal end of the magnet wire, either directly or indirectly.

(21) In some of these embodiments, the magnet wire further comprises a magnet wire distal terminus at the distal end of the magnet wire, the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises a ferrule attached to the magnet wire distal terminus, and the grasper magnet is attached to the ferrule.

(22) In some embodiments, the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the grasper arm, either directly or indirectly.

(23) In some embodiments, the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the grasper wire, either directly or indirectly.

(24) In some embodiments, the grasper arm further comprises an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm; the grasper arm is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm has a size sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm is in the second position and to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the grasper arm is in the first position, and sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the grasper arm is in the first position.

(25) In some embodiments, the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first grasper arm further comprising an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the first grasper arm; the second grasper arm further comprising an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the second grasper arm; the first and second grasper arms are reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the first and second grasper arms from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; and the enlarged distal termini of the first and second grasper arms have sizes sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms are in the second position and to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position, and sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position.

(26) In some of these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises at least one additional grasper wire and at least one additional grasper arm extending distally from the at

least one additional grasper wire.

(27) In some embodiments, the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; and the grasper arm loop has a thickness sufficiently great to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(28) In some embodiments, the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the first and second grasper arms further comprise an enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large, and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently small, to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently small to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the grasper arm loop is in the first position; and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(29) In some embodiments, the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop is in an elastically deformed closed state when the grasper arm loop is in the first position; the grasper arm loop reversibly expands to an open state when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position;

and the grasper arm loop snares the suture magnet of the magnetic suture to block the suture magnet from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(30) In some of these embodiments, the grasper arm loop is formed of a shape memory alloy.

(31) In some embodiments, the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms comprise curved portions adjacent their distal ends; the first and second grasper arms are reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the first and second grasper arms from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the proximal-to-intermediate portions of the first and second grasper arms are substantially parallel to the needle body axis and the curved portions adjacent the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms curve inwardly toward the needle body axis when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position; at least one of the first or second grasper arms pivots reversibly outwardly from the needle body axis sufficiently far to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms are in the second position; and the curved portions adjacent the distal ends of the two grasper arms contact the magnetic suture to block the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position.

(32) In some embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises a lock mechanism that can be reversibly engaged to prevent translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in the first direction and/or the second direction.

(33) In some of these embodiments, the lock mechanism can be reversibly engaged in a first setting that prevents translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen when the distal end of the grasper arm is inside the needle lumen and reversibly engaged in a second setting that prevents translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen when the grasper magnet is outside of the needle lumen.

(34) In some of these embodiments, maintaining the lock mechanism in the first setting or the second setting does not require energy input.

(35) A system for passing a magnetic suture also is disclosed. The system comprises the magnet-assisted suture grasper. The system also comprises a magnetic suture comprising a suture magnet and a suture extending from the suture magnet.

(36) Another system for passing a magnetic suture also is disclosed. The system comprises the magnet-assisted suture grasper. The system also comprises a magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet and a bifurcated suture extending from the suture magnet and forming a suture loop.

(37) In some embodiments, the system further comprises a cartridge tube, wherein the cartridge tube comprises a cartridge tube proximal opening, a cartridge tube distal opening, and a cartridge tube lumen therebetween; the suture loop traverses the cartridge tube lumen based on having been inserted through the cartridge tube distal opening; and the suture magnet is disposed outside of the cartridge tube lumen adjacent the cartridge tube distal opening.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) These and other features, aspects, and advantages of the present disclosure are better understood

when the following detailed description is read with reference to the accompanying drawings, which are as follows.

(2) FIG. 1 is a side view of a first embodiment of a magnet-assisted suture grasper comprising a suture retrieval needle, a retriever body, a grasper wire, a grasper arm, and a grasper magnet, as disclosed herein, in which the grasper arm is in a position exposing the grasper magnet and allowing contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto, termed the second position, as discussed herein.

(3) FIG. 2 is a sectional view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in a position sequestering the grasper magnet within the needle lumen, termed the first position, as discussed herein.

(4) FIG. 3 is a front view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(5) FIG. 4 is a back view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1.

(6) FIG. 5 is a side view of a portion of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1 comprising the retriever body, the grasper wire, the grasper arm, and the grasper magnet, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(7) FIG. 6 is a top view of the portion of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 5, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(8) FIG. 7 is an expanded side view of a distal end of the portion of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 5, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(9) FIG. 8 is an expanded top view of a distal end of the portion of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 5, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(10) FIG. 9 is a side view of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1.

(11) FIG. 10 is a top view of the suture retrieval needle of FIG. 9.

(12) FIG. 11 is a side view of a second embodiment of a magnet-assisted suture grasper comprising a suture retrieval needle, a retriever body, a grasper wire, a grasper arm, and a grasper magnet as disclosed herein, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(13) FIG. 12 is a top view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(14) FIG. 13 is a bottom view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(15) FIG. 14 is a front view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(16) FIG. 15 is a back view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the first position.

(17) FIG. 16 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(18) FIG. 17 is a top view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(19) FIG. 18 is a bottom view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(20) FIG. 19 is a front view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(21) FIG. 20 a perspective view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(22) FIG. 21 a sectional view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11.

(23) FIG. 22 is an expanded perspective view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(24) FIG. 23 is a proximal end view of a barrel of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11.

- (25) FIG. 24 is a partial longitudinal view of the barrel of FIG. 23.
- (26) FIG. 25 is a partial sectional view of the barrel of FIG. 23 through guide channels of the barrel.
- (27) FIG. 26 is a partial sectional view of the barrel of FIG. 23 perpendicular to guide channels of the barrel.
- (28) FIG. 27 is a perspective view of a lock cam of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11.
- (29) FIG. 28 is a side view of the lock cam of FIG. 27.
- (30) FIG. 29 is a side view of a drive cam of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11.
- (31) FIG. 30 is a perspective view of the drive cam of FIG. 29.
- (32) FIG. 31 is a perspective view of an advancer assembly of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11.
- (33) FIG. 32 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in an unlocked retracted position and the grasper arm is in the first position.
- (34) FIG. 33 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the unlocked retracted position and the grasper arm is in the first position.
- (35) FIG. 34 is a partial sectional view of a subset of components of the advancer assembly of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the unlocked retracted position.
- (36) FIG. 35 is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the unlocked retracted position and the grasper arm is in the first position.
- (37) FIG. 36 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in a locked intermediate position and the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position.
- (38) FIG. 37 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position and the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position.
- (39) FIG. 38 is a partial sectional view of a subset of components of the advancer assembly of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position.
- (40) FIG. 39 is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position and the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position.
- (41) FIG. 40 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in a locked extended position and the grasper arm is in the second position.
- (42) FIG. 41 is a side view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position and the grasper arm is in the second position.
- (43) FIG. 42 is a partial sectional view of a subset of parts of the advancer assembly of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position.
- (44) FIG. 43 is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in the second position. This also is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position and the grasper arm is in the second position.
- (45) FIG. 44 is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in the second position and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture. This also is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position, the grasper arm is in the second position, and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture.
- (46) FIG. 45 is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in

which the grasper arm is in the second position and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture. This also is a side view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position, the grasper arm is in the second position, and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture.

(47) FIG. 46 is a sectional view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in the first position, and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture has been captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper. This also is a sectional view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the unlocked retracted position, the grasper arm is in the first position, and the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture has been captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper.

(48) FIG. 47 is a sectional view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 1, in which the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position, and an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm is grasping the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture remains captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper. This also is a sectional view of the distal end of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position, the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position, and an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm is grasping the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture remains captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper.

(49) FIG. 48 is a partial sectional view of a subset of parts of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position and the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position.

(50) FIG. 49A-C is a sectional view of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the advancer assembly is in the locked intermediate position and the grasper arm is in a position intermediate between the first position and the second position.

(51) FIG. 50 is a top view of the grasper arm of the magnet-assisted suture grasper of FIG. 11, in which the grasper arm is in the second position.

(52) FIG. 51 is a side view of a first alternate embodiment of a grasper arm of a magnet-assisted suture grasper as disclosed herein.

(53) FIG. 52 is a side view of a second alternate embodiment of a grasper arm of a magnet-assisted suture grasper as disclosed herein.

(54) FIG. 53 is a side view of a third alternate embodiment of a grasper arm of a magnet-assisted suture grasper as disclosed herein.

(55) FIG. 54 is a top view of a magnetic suture loop as disclosed herein.

(56) FIG. 55 is an expanded view of a loop-end and a magnet-end of the magnetic suture loop of FIG. 54.

(57) FIG. 56 is a front view of the magnetic suture loop of FIG. 54.

(58) FIG. 57 is a back view of the magnetic suture loop of FIG. 54.

(59) FIG. 58 is an expanded sectional view of the magnet-end of the magnetic suture loop of FIG. 54.

(60) FIG. 59 is a side view of a preloaded magnetic suture cartridge as disclosed herein.

(61) FIG. 60 is a sectional view of the magnet-end of the preloaded magnetic suture cartridge of FIG. 59.

(62) FIG. 61 is a sectional view of the loop-end of the preloaded magnetic suture cartridge of FIG. 59.

(63) FIG. **62** is a side view of the preloaded magnetic suture cartridge of FIG. **59** in an introducer needle.

(64) FIG. **63** is a side view of an alternate embodiment a preloaded magnetic suture cartridge as disclosed herein in which the magnet-end of the preloaded magnetic suture cartridge is curved.

(65) FIG. **64** is a side view of a fourth alternate embodiment of a grasper arm of a magnet-assisted suture grasper as disclosed herein.

(66) FIG. **65** is a sectional view of the fourth alternate embodiment of the grasper arm of FIG. **64**.

(67) FIG. **66** is a perspective view of the fourth alternate embodiment of the grasper arm of FIG. **64**, in which the grasper magnet of the magnet-assisted suture grasper is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture.

(68) FIG. **67** is a perspective view of the fourth alternate embodiment of the grasper arm of FIG. **64**, in which the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture has been captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper.

(69) FIG. **68** is a sectional view of the fourth alternate embodiment of the grasper arm of FIG. **64**, in which the grasper magnet is attracting a magnetic suture and in contact with the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture has been captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper.

(70) FIG. **69** is a sectional view of the fourth alternate embodiment of the grasper arm of FIG. **64**, in which the distal end of the grasper arm is grasping the magnetic suture, such that the magnetic suture remains captured within the needle lumen of the suture retrieval needle of the magnet-assisted suture grasper.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(71) A magnet-assisted suture grasper for grasping a magnetic suture is disclosed. The magnet-assisted suture grasper comprises: (a) a suture retrieval needle comprising a proximal end, a distal end, and a needle body extending therebetween, the needle body defining a needle body axis between the proximal and distal ends of the suture retrieval needle, the needle body having a proximal hole, a distal hole, and a needle lumen extending therebetween along the needle body axis; (b) a retriever body disposed within the needle lumen and translatable therein along the needle body axis; (c) a grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; (d) a grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the grasper arm extending from the distal end of the grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between a first position and a second position; and (e) a grasper magnet being disposed adjacent the proximal-to-intermediate portion of the grasper arm, the magnet-assisted suture grasper sequestering the grasper magnet within the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the first position and exposing the grasper magnet from the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the second position. The distal end of the grasper arm extends further distally than the grasper magnet. Translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the first position to the second position, thereby exposing the grasper magnet and allowing contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto. Translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a second direction opposite the first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the second position to the first position, thereby sequestering the grasper magnet and grasping the magnetic suture within the needle lumen.

(72) Our magnet-assisted suture grasper addresses the technical difficulty associated with capturing and retrieving sutures under indirect non-stereoscopic visualization. Our magnet-assisted suture grasper involves use of two dipole magnets, a grasper magnet of a magnet-assisted suture grasper and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture, to assist with the initial positioning and holding of a magnetic suture while the magnetic suture is captured by a secondary mechanical means of the magnet-assisted suture grasper. The use of the two dipole magnets allows for a self-aligning

feature, whereby the attractive forces of the northern and southern poles of the grasper magnet and the suture magnet cause the two magnets to align in a predictable manner, improving aspects of repeatability and reliability of function. Our magnet-assisted suture grasper greatly reduces the need to precisely position a suture passer, as the two magnetic aspects need only be brought near enough to one another that the magnetic fields can interact. The magnetic aspect of the suture is pulled into contact with the grasper magnet. This occurs without need for precise positioning to make contact. The secondary mechanical means then provides a steady-state connection between the magnetic suture and the magnet-assisted suture grasper that serves to hold the suture to the magnet-assisted suture grasper, allowing retrieval of the suture through soft tissue of a patient without needing to rely on magnetic attraction between the grasper magnet and the suture magnetic during the retrieval.

(73) While we initially envisioned that sutures would be retrieved from a patient's body relying on the magnetic attraction between the grasper magnet and the suture magnet, in vitro testing revealed a problem whereby frictional drag associated with pulling a suture through soft tissues was greater than the attractive force between the grasper magnet and the suture magnet, resulting in separation of the magnets. The two magnets were too small. The size of the magnets is restricted by the need to pass them through a cannula for delivery, and the desire to minimize the size of the cannula to minimize trauma associated with tissue penetration by the cannula. We could not increase the size of the magnets to provide a greater attractive strength. We realized, though, that we could solve this problem by using a mechanical trap that works in conjunction with the walls of the cannula to secure the suture against greater loads than the magnetic connection can withstand.

(74) More specifically, initially we intended to incorporate a magnetic suture, including a suture magnet, such as the magnetic suture described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667, and a device including a magnetic suture retriever with a magnetic end, similar to the retrieval probe of the magnetic U-stitch suturing device described in U.S. Pat. No. 10,245,021. The suture would be introduced using a 17 gauge hypodermic needle. For certain procedures, such as the inguinal hernia repair technique referenced above, the needle must then be removed before introduction of a retriever. In the inguinal hernia repair procedure, the suture would be deposited with the magnetic end inside the peritoneal cavity, and the suture extending through the abdominal wall. The magnetic suture retriever would then be introduced through the same percutaneous site, using a 17 gauge needle. This could be a second needle, or it could be the same needle that was used to introduce the suture. The magnetic suture retriever would then be brought near the magnetic end of the suture so that the magnets would connect. Once the magnets were connected, the magnetic retriever would be withdrawn, pulling the suture with it.

(75) While prototyping this device, we determined that the attractive force between the magnets of the magnetic suture retriever and the magnetic suture was not strong enough to resist the frictional drag that results from pulling the suture through soft tissue. For comparison, for the magnetic U-stitch device described in U.S. Pat. No. 10,245,021, the suture never contacts tissue during retrieval. Instead, the suture travels through one cannula, into an open space, and then back through another cannula. There is minimal drag created by passing the suture through these cannulas. However, in the case of the inguinal hernia procedure, which is typically done on pediatric patients, there is not sufficient room for two needles to occupy relevant space in the patient simultaneously. The suture needs to be dropped first from an introducer needle. Then the introducer needle needs to be removed. Then the magnetic suture retriever would need to be able to retrieve the suture.

(76) We realized, though, that the frictional drag created by pulling the suture through soft tissue is a problem. The drag creates a tensile load on the suture which is greater than the attractive force between the magnets, causing the magnets to disconnect and the suture to be dropped. Due to the small size of the pediatric patients, increasing the size of the introducer needle would be disadvantageous. However, without increasing the size of the needle, the diameter of magnets that can be used is limited, which limits the strength of the attractive force between the magnets. A

current design for the magnetic U-stitch device uses a 17 gauge XT wall hypodermic needle that has an inner lumen diameter of 0.049-0.051 inches (1.24 to 1.30 mm), accounting for manufacturing tolerances. The corresponding magnet has a nominal outer diameter of 0.035 inches (0.889 mm), and a ferrule diameter of 0.037 ± 0.001 inches (0.940 ± 0.025 mm). Each magnet has a pull force of approximately 0.102 lbf (0.454 N). Even increasing the magnet diameter to the theoretical max of 0.042 inches (1.07 mm), allowing for manufacturing tolerances and a minimal clearance of only 0.001 inches (0.025 mm), would only increase that pull force to approximately 0.145 lbf (0.645 N). A much larger magnet would be needed to overcome the drag of the soft tissue, but a larger magnet cannot be used due to the limitation imposed on needle size.

(77) We have solved this problem, among other ways, by pairing the magnet on the retrieval device, termed a grasper magnet, with a mechanical arm, termed a grasper arm, with an enlarged distal terminus, a loop configuration, and/or other features that can mechanically block the exit path of the magnetic suture once the suture has been pulled into the needle of the retrieval device. With the mechanical block in place, the ability to retain the magnetic suture against a tensile load is limited only by the strength of the mechanical arm, which can be far greater than the attractive force between the small grasper magnet and the small suture magnet. Our testing shows that the grasper arm advantageously retains the magnetic suture against forces far greater than the grasper magnet and the suture magnet can withstand. Indeed, the grasper arm advantageously retains the magnetic suture against forces great enough to break the suture, which is required to have a tensile strength of at least 3 lbf (13 N) by USP standards. The mechanical solution is therefore at least approximately 30 times stronger than the grasper magnet and suture magnet alone.

(78) Importantly, we realized that the retrieval instrument with a grasper magnet only needs to be brought near enough to the magnetic suture for the magnetic fields of the grasper magnet and the suture magnet to interact. Advantageously, this does not require very precise positioning. The magnetic fields are oriented such that when the fields begin to interact, the suture magnet is pulled towards the grasper magnet and the magnets self-align and connect in the same orientation each time. While the strength of the grasper magnet and the suture magnet is not great enough to pull the magnetic suture through soft tissue on its own, we realized that it is strong enough to keep the magnets in contact with each other while the retrieval instrument is manipulated, allowing the user to mechanically capture the magnetic suture, even if the retrieval instrument and the magnetic suture are not held very steady.

(79) Optionally, the magnet-assisted suture grasper can further comprise a lock mechanism that can be reversibly engaged to prevent translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen.

(80) Our magnet-assisted suture grasper that optionally includes the lock mechanism can incorporate an incompressible and reversible mechanical lock that, when engaged, fixes the longitudinal position of the grasper arm in at least one direction, and thereby also fixes the position of a magnetic suture being grasped by the grasper arm in the same direction. When engaged, the mechanical lock advantageously bears fully any tensile load applied to the magnetic suture in the same direction. The mechanical lock provides for a single equiposed position. Moreover, a return spring may be added to the magnet-assisted suture grasper to advantageously provide a second equiposed position, allowing the magnet-assisted suture grasper to be switched between positions with a momentary energy input, but requiring no additional energy input to maintain either position.

(81) For comparison, conventional suture passers make use of a spring located between a moveable plunger element and a fixed body element. According to designs of the conventional suture passers, depressing the plunger element by the application of external force compresses the spring, causing the suture passer to transition from a closed position to an open position. Upon release of the plunger element, and thus in the absence of external force, the spring exerts a counterforce back upon the plunger, which returns the suture passer from the open position to the closed position. The conventional suture passers lack a mechanical lock, and thus rely solely on the spring to resist

tensile loading of the suture in the direction which acts to pull the suture out of the suture passer. The spring thus needs to be stiff enough that the force required to compress the spring to a position where the suture passer opens sufficiently far to release the suture is greater than the expected loads that will be placed on the suture during retrieval. Additionally, since the conventional suture passers provide for only one equipoised position, which is the closed position, the operator must continually apply an external force great enough to compress the spring in order to maintain an open position of the suture passer while retrieving a suture.

(82) With our magnet-assisted suture grasper including the lock mechanism, these loads are born by the mechanical lock rather than a spring. As a result, a lighter spring can be used, which reduces the operational force needed to move our magnet-assisted suture grasper between open and closed positions. This allows our magnet-assisted suture grasper to be slidingly operated with a single finger, which allows for a more precise gripping style better suited to delicate procedures, such as, for example, dissection and mobilization of the spermatic cord structures away from the peritoneum, such as in percutaneous inguinal ring suturing. Moreover, because the mechanical lock provides an equipoised closed position, the spring action can be reversed to also create an equipoised open position. This advantageously allows an operator to manipulate our magnet-assisted suture grasper in an open position without having to hold forcefully against a spring.

(83) To quantify the significance of this change, consider the design of a suture passer needed to retrieve a 3-0 polyester suture. The minimum tensile strength of a non-absorbable class I suture of 3-0 size, as required by USP <881> is 0.96 kgf (approximately 9.4 N), while the typical tensile strength of a 3-0 polyester braided suture has been observed to be around 1.5-2.0 kgf (approximately 15 to 20 N). In designing our magnet-assisted suture grasper, we realized that it would be desirable to make our magnet-assisted suture grasper such that it could retain sutures up to the full tensile capacity of the sutures.

(84) Using a conventional suture passer, for which the return spring must retain a suture against tensile loading, the spring must be sufficiently stiff to resist compression to a point where the suture passer opens enough to release the suture at up to 2.0 kgf (approximately 20 N). This in turn means that an input force of >2.0 kgf (greater than approximately 20 N) will be required to compress the spring to the open position. Additionally, the operator must apply this >2.0 kgf (greater than approximately 20 N) force continually to maintain the open position.

(85) In our design, the spring only needs to overcome the frictional drag between sliding components. We have found that an input force of 0.045 kgf (approximately 0.44 N) provides sufficient force with an adequate safety factor to assure that our magnet-assisted suture grasper is always returned to the fully open position by the spring. This is the minimum force required by the spring at the lower bound of travel. The maximum force that the spring generates occurs at the upper bound of travel. Working within the geometric constraints of our current design, we may select a typical open-ended music wire spring having an outer diameter of 0.195 inches (4.95 mm) and a wire diameter of 0.008 inches (0.2 mm) and a free length of 3.500 inches (88.90 mm), with 21 coils disposed between ends. We find this spring has a calculated spring rate of 0.195 kgf (1.91 N), resulting in a preload of 0.046 kgf (0.45 N) at the minimal extent of travel, meeting our 0.045 kgf (0.44 N) requirement, and a calculated peak load of 0.063 kgf (0.618 N) at the maximal extent of travel.

(86) Compared to the conventional suture passer, our magnet-assisted suture passer including the lock mechanism advantageously results in a 96.8% decrease in the force needed to move the device between open and closed positions. Additionally, since our magnet-assisted suture passer including the lock mechanism provides for equipoised closed and open positions, this force is only needed momentarily to change positions, and does not need to be continually applied while maneuvering our magnet-assisted suture passer including the lock mechanism.

(87) FIG. 1, with reference to FIGS. 43-47, illustrates a magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** for grasping a magnetic suture **200** corresponding to a first embodiment **1001** that does not comprise a

lock mechanism. FIG. 11, with reference to FIGS. 43-47, illustrates a magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** for grasping a magnetic suture **200** corresponding to a second embodiment **1002** that comprises a lock mechanism. Additional views of the first embodiment **1001** are shown in FIGS. 2-10. Additional views of the second embodiment **1002** are shown in FIGS. 12-42, FIG. 48, and FIG. 49A-C. The first embodiment **1001** and the second embodiment **1002** are discussed together with respect to features and variations that apply to both. The first embodiment **1001** also is discussed with respect to a hub, a handle, and a return mechanism and operation of the first embodiment **1001**. The second embodiment **1002** also is discussed with respect to features and variations that relate to the lock mechanism and operation of the second embodiment **1002**.

(88) With reference to FIG. 44, the magnetic suture **200** to be grasped can comprise a suture magnet **202** and a suture **204** extending from the suture magnet **202**. The magnetic suture **200** can be, for example, a magnetic suture as described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667, which is incorporated herein by reference. Thus, the magnetic suture **200** can further comprise a ferrule **206** with a tapered region **208** in which the suture **204** is provided knotted and secured with an adhesive and a straight region **210** in which the suture magnet **202** is provided.

(89) As shown in FIG. 1, FIG. 9, and FIG. 10 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIGS. 11-13 for the second embodiment **1002**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** comprises a suture retrieval needle **102** comprising a proximal end **104**, a distal end **106**, and a needle body **108** extending therebetween. The needle body **108** defines a needle body axis **110** between the proximal end **104** and distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. The needle body **108** has a proximal hole **112**, a distal hole **114**, and a needle lumen **116** extending therebetween along the needle body axis **110**.

(90) As shown in FIG. 1, FIG. 9, and FIG. 10 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIGS. 11-13 for the second embodiment **1002**, the suture retrieval needle **102** can be a hypodermic needle. For example, the suture retrieval needle **102** can be an introducer needle designed for introducing guide wires into a vessel, applied here as the suture retrieval needle **102**. Also for example, the suture retrieval needle **102** can be a 24-gauge needle, a 21-gauge needle, an 18-gauge needle, a 17-gauge needle, a 16-gauge needle, or a 14 gauge needle.

(91) Accordingly, in some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle **102** is a hypodermic needle. In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle **102** is an introducer needle. In some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle **102** is a 24-gauge needle, a 21-gauge needle, an 18-gauge needle, a 17-gauge needle, a 16-gauge needle, or a 14 gauge needle.

(92) As shown in FIG. 1, FIG. 9, and FIG. 10 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIGS. 11-13 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments the suture retrieval needle **102** is straight. In accordance with these embodiments, the needle body axis **110** thereby is straight. Alternatively, in some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle **102** is curved. In accordance with these embodiments, the needle body axis **110** thereby is curved. In some embodiments, one or more portions of the suture retrieval needle **102** can be straight, and one or more portions can be curved. For example, in some embodiments, the suture retrieval needle **102** includes a curve at or near its distal end **106** but otherwise is straight. In accordance with these embodiments, the needle body axis **110** also includes a curve at or near the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102**, but otherwise is straight.

(93) As shown in FIG. 9 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 11 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments the suture retrieval needle **102** has a sharp tip **118**. This can be advantageous for piercing tissue during insertion of the suture retrieval needle **102** into a patient.

(94) As shown in FIG. 1 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 11 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments the suture retrieval needle **102** further comprises a hub **119**. The hub **119** can have an open lumen.

(95) As shown in FIG. 1 and FIG. 5 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** also comprises a retriever body **146**. The retriever body **146** is disposed within the needle lumen **116** and translatable therein along the

needle body axis **110**. The retriever body **146** can be made from a polymer, such as nylon, polyether ether ketone, polycarbonate, or acrylonitrile butadiene styrene, or a metal, such as stainless steel or Nitinol.

(96) As shown in FIG. 5 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 48 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments, the retriever body **146** comprises a proximal end **170**, a distal end **172**, and a retriever tube **174** extending therebetween. In these embodiments, the retriever tube **174** defines a retriever tube axis **176** between the proximal end **170** and distal end **172** of the retriever body **146**, the retriever tube **174** has a proximal hole **178**, a distal hole **180**, and a retriever tube lumen **182** extending therebetween along the retriever tube axis **176**. In these embodiments, the proximal hole **178** of the retriever tube **174** is in fluid communication with the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108** through the retriever tube lumen **182** and the needle lumen **116**. In these embodiments, the retriever body **146** preferably is made from a polymer such as nylon to facilitate making the retriever body **146** including the retriever tube lumen **182**.

(97) This can be advantageous by allowing recovery of liquids and/or gasses from a surgical site of a patient and/or delivery of contrast agents to the surgical site through the retriever tube lumen **182** of the retriever body **146**. Providing the ability to exchange fluids through the retriever body **146** and thus through the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** broadens the applicability of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** for use with interventional techniques that employ fluid exchange to confirm the intracorporeal position of the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100**. For example, a need exists within the field of interventional radiology for the ability to confirm the location of cannulas inside the gastric lumens of patients during gastropexy. With the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** comprising the retriever body **146** comprising the retriever tube lumen **182**, following introduction of the suture retrieval needle **102** into a patient, aspiration of a small amount of stomach juice or air can be used to confirm the intraluminal position of the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. Alternatively, a small amount of liquid radiographic contrast agent can be injected through the retriever tube lumen **182** of the retriever body **146** into the gastric lumen of the patient, allowing the intraluminal position to be confirmed through radiographic imaging.

(98) Also in some embodiments the retriever body **146** can be transparent. This allows for the use of photo-initiated adhesives, which can be advantageous for assembly of components. Photo-initiated adhesives provide more open time for component positioning, while requiring minimal fixture time due to a very rapid cure profile.

(99) As shown in FIG. 2 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 33 and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, with reference to FIG. 50 for both the first embodiment **1001** and the second embodiment **1002**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** also comprises a grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124**.

(100) The grasper wire **120** is fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**. This can be accomplished by inserting the proximal end **122** of the grasper wire **120** into the retriever body **146** and securing the grasper wire **120** to the retriever body **146** so that it is translationally and rotationally fixed to the retriever body **146**. The preferred method of assembly is to insert the grasper wire **120** into a lumen of the retriever body **146** and apply an adhesive to join the grasper wire **120** to the retriever body **146**. However, other means of attachment are also suitable, and may be preferable based on size, shape, or application. Such other means include mechanical means, e.g., swaged, interference fit, or pinned, or other means, such as brazing, welding, soldering, etc.

(101) The grasper wire **120** can be, for example, a metal wire, such as a Nitinol wire or a stainless steel wire, or a plastic wire, among other types of wire. The grasper wire **120** can be formed, for example, as a solid wire, a stranded wire, or a braided wire. The grasper wire **120** can have a shape, for example, based on being a shaped wire and/or a stamped wire. The grasper wire **120** can comprise, for example, one or more wires joined together at one or more common points, for example, by welding, soldering, braiding, crimping, adhesive, or other means.

(102) As shown in FIG. 1, FIG. 2, and FIGS. 5-8 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16 and FIG. 22 for the second embodiment **1002**, with reference to FIG. 50 for both the first embodiment **1001** and the second embodiment **1002**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** also comprises a grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**. Like the grasper wire **120**, the grasper arm **126** also can be, for example, a wire, although other structures, such as a tube or other elongated member can be suitable too. Regarding the grasper arm **126** being a wire, the grasper arm **126** can be, for example, a metal wire, such as a Nitinol wire or a stainless steel wire, or a plastic wire, and can be formed, for example, as a solid wire, a stranded wire, or a braided wire, and can have a shape, for example, based on being a shaped wire and/or a stamped wire, and can comprise, for example, one or more wires joined together at one or more common points, for example, by welding, soldering, braiding, crimping, adhesive, or other means.

(103) As shown in FIG. 1 and FIG. 2 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16 and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, the grasper arm **126** extends from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** and is reversibly moveable between a first position **136** and a second position **138**.

(104) As shown for in FIG. 50 for both the first embodiment **1001** and the second embodiment **1002**, the grasper arm **126** can extend from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120**, among other ways, based on the grasper arm **126** being integral to the grasper wire **120**. By this it is meant that the grasper arm **126** and the grasper wire **120** can be adjacent portions of a single segment of wire, e.g., a solid, stranded, or braided wire segment from which the grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** have been formed. In such examples the grasper arm **126** extends from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** based on the grasper arm **126** and the grasper wire **120** forming a continuous wire segment through the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120**.

(105) Also for example, the grasper arm **126** can extend from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** directly, based on adhesion or other direct attachment of the grasper arm **126** to the grasper wire **120**. In these examples the grasper arm **126** can extend from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** based on the grasper arm **126** and the grasper wire **120** forming wire segments connected at the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** by adhesion or other direct attachment.

(106) Also for example, the grasper arm **126** can extend from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** indirectly, based on attachment through one, two, or more intermediate parts, such as a ferrule, a ring, or a sleeve, among other intermediate parts. In these examples the grasper arm **126** can extend from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** based on the grasper arm **126** and the grasper wire **120** forming wire segments connected at the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** via intermediate parts.

(107) As shown in FIG. 1 and FIGS. 5-8 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16, FIG. 17, FIG. 22, and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** also comprises a grasper magnet **140** disposed adjacent the proximal-to-intermediate portion **130** of the grasper arm **126**. The magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** sequesters the grasper magnet **140** within the needle lumen **116** when the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136** and exposes the grasper magnet **140** from the needle lumen **116** when the at least grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**. The grasper magnet **140** can be, for example, a permanent dipole magnet.

(108) As shown in FIG. 2 and FIG. 7 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16, FIG. 22, and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises a magnet wire **160** having a proximal end **162** and a distal end **164**, wherein the proximal end **162** of the magnet wire **160** is fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146** and the grasper magnet **140** is fixedly attached to the distal end **164** of the magnet wire **160**, either directly, e.g., based on adhesion or other direct attachment, or indirectly, e.g., based on attachment through one or more intermediate parts, such as a ferrule, ring, or sleeve, among other intermediate parts. In accordance with these embodiments, translation of the retriever body **146** also results in translation of the magnet wire **160**, and thus also the grasper magnet **140**.

(109) The magnet wire **160** can be fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146** by inserting the proximal end **162** of the magnet wire **160** into the retriever body **146** and securing the magnet wire **160** to the retriever body **146** so that the magnet wire **160** is translationally and rotationally fixed to the retriever body **146**. Like for the grasper wire **120**, the preferred method of assembly is to insert the magnet wire **160** into a lumen of the retriever body **146** and apply an adhesive to join the magnet wire **160** to the retriever body **146**, but other means of attachment are also suitable.

(110) As shown in FIG. 7 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 22 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some of these embodiments the magnet wire **160** further comprises a magnet wire distal terminus **166** at the distal end **164** of the magnet wire **160**, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises a ferrule **168** attached to the magnet wire distal terminus **166** at the distal end **164** of the magnet wire **160**, and the grasper magnet **140** is attached to the ferrule **168**.

(111) The magnet wire **160** can be, for example, a metal wire, such as a Nitinol wire or a stainless steel wire, or a plastic wire, and can be formed, for example, as a solid wire, a stranded wire, or a braided wire, and can have a shape, for example, based on being a shaped wire and/or a stamped wire, and can comprise, for example, one or more wires joined together at one or more common points, for example, by welding, soldering, braiding, crimping, adhesive, or other means.

(112) Considering attachment of the grasper magnet **140** to the magnet wire **160** in more detail, the grasper magnet **140** can be attached to the magnet wire **160**, for example, similarly as described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667 for attachment of a magnet to a suture. This can be accomplished as follows. The grasper magnet **140** can be attached to a ferrule **168**, which is attached to a magnet wire **160** having an enlarged magnet wire distal terminus **166**. With reference to U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667, the enlarged magnet wire distal terminus **166** would replace the knot tied in a suture. A ball end is the preferred shape for the magnet wire distal terminus **166** and a mono-filament with a round cross-section is the preferred shape of the magnet wire **160**. However, as long as the magnet wire **160** and the magnet wire distal terminus **166** are sized appropriately, other constructions and final shapes would also be suitable. The magnet wire distal terminus **166** may be formed into any shape, e.g., cubic, cylindrical, pyramidal, organic, etc., and the magnet wire **160** may be of any cross sectional shape, e.g., square, rectangular, cruciform, etc., and may be of mono- or multi-filament construction.

(113) The magnet wire **160** must be sized small enough to fit through the small opening of the ferrule **168**, while the magnet wire distal terminus **166** must be sized larger than the small opening of the ferrule **168** and smaller than the large opening of the ferrule **168**. The magnet wire distal terminus **166** may be integrated into the magnet wire **160**, e.g., the magnet wire distal terminus **166** can be melt formed, coined, bent, etc., or it may be a separate component. If a separate component, it may be attached by mechanical means, e.g., swaged, threaded, interference fit, pinned, etc., by adhesive means, or by other means, e.g., welding, soldering, brazing, etc.

(114) To assemble the grasper magnet **140**, the ferrule **168**, and the magnet wire **160**, the magnet wire **160** is first passed through the ferrule **168** from its distal end **164** to its proximal end **162**, so that the magnet wire distal terminus **166** becomes positioned inside the ferrule **168**. The grasper magnet **140** is then installed from the distal end, and attached to the ferrule **168**. The grasper magnet **140** can be attached by mechanical means, e.g., swaged, threaded, interference fit, pinned, etc., or adhesive means or other means, e.g., welding, brazing, etc. Once the grasper magnet **140** is attached, the magnet wire distal terminus **166** is permanently captured between the grasper magnet **140** and the ferrule **168**, and the sub-assembly is complete.

(115) As shown in FIG. 2 and FIG. 7 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16, FIG. 22, and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, in some embodiments of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** that further comprises a magnet wire **160** to which the grasper magnet **140** is fixedly attached as described, the grasper magnet **140** is displaced radially from the needle body axis **110** when the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**. This can be advantageous by providing an operator of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** an additional range of motion to move the

grasper magnet **140** within a site of a patient by rotation of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** and thus greater versatility in positioning the grasper magnet **140** relative to a magnetic suture **200** in the site.

(116) Alternatively or additionally, in some embodiments the grasper magnet **140** is fixedly attached to the grasper wire **120** and/or the grasper arm **126**, again either directly, e.g., based on adhesion or other direct attachment, or indirectly, e.g., based on attachment through one or more intermediate parts, such as a ferrule, ring, or sleeve, among other intermediate parts. This can be advantageous by allowing for use of a shorter grasper arm **126** relative to embodiments in which the grasper magnet **140** is fixedly attached to a grasper wire **120**. As shown in FIG. 7 and FIG. 8 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 22 and FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** extends further distally than the grasper magnet **140**. This means that when the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136** that the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** extends further distally within the needle lumen **116** than does any portion of the grasper magnet **140**. This also means that when the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138** that the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** extends further distally from the suture retrieval needle **102** than does any portion of the grasper magnet **140**. This also means that when the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138** that the grasper magnet **140** is closer to the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102** than is the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126**.

(117) As shown by comparison of FIG. 2 with FIG. 1 for the first embodiment **1001** and by comparison of FIG. 35 with FIG. 16 for the second embodiment **1002**, and with reference to FIG. 9 for the first embodiment **1001**, FIG. 11 for the second embodiment **1002**, and FIGS. 43-45 for both, translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in a first direction along the needle body axis **110** causes the grasper arm **126** to move from the first position **136** to the second position **138**, thereby exposing the grasper magnet **140** and allowing contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto. The translation of the retriever body **146** results in translation of the grasper wire **120** and thus translation of the grasper arm **126**. The translation of the retriever body **146** in the first direction can be translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in a direction from the proximal end **104** of the suture retrieval needle **102** toward the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. When the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136** the grasper magnet **140** can be disposed entirely inside the needle lumen **116**, and thus sequestered within the needle lumen **116**. In accordance with these embodiments, such translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in the first direction can move the grasper magnet **140** from inside the needle lumen **116** to outside the needle lumen **116**, thus exposing the grasper magnet **140**.

(118) The grasper arm **126** can be sufficiently stiff so that translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in the first direction moves the grasper arm **126** from inside the needle lumen **116** to outside the needle lumen **116**, thus exposing the grasper magnet **140**. This may be accomplished by making the grasper arm **126** sufficiently stiff so as to moveable by translation of retriever body **146**.

(119) As shown by comparison of FIG. 1 with FIG. 2 for the first embodiment **1001** and by comparison of FIG. 16 with FIG. 35 for the second embodiment **1002**, and with reference to FIG. 9 for the first embodiment **1001**, FIG. 11 for the second embodiment **1002**, and FIG. 45 and FIG. 46 for both, translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in a second direction opposite the first direction along the needle body axis **110** causes the grasper arm **126** to move from the second position **138** to the first position **136**, thereby sequestering the grasper magnet **140** and grasping the magnetic suture **200** within the needle lumen **116**. The translation of the retriever body **146** in the second direction can be translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in a direction from the distal end **106** of suture retrieval needle **102** toward the proximal end **104** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. Such translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in the second direction can move the grasper magnet **140** from outside the needle lumen **116** to

inside the needle lumen **116**, thus sequestering the grasper magnet **140** again and grasping the magnetic suture **200** within the needle lumen **116**.

(120) This can be accomplished as follows. Because the grasper magnet **140** is closer to the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102** than is the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** while the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**, when a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** contacts the grasper magnet **140** and the retriever body **146** is translated in the second direction to the first position **136**, the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** enter the needle lumen **116** before the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** does. Once the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** has followed the suture magnet **202** into the needle lumen **116**, the suture magnet **202** cannot exit the needle lumen **116** while the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** remains in the needle lumen **116**. The grasper arm **126** blocks exit of the suture magnet **202**, thereby mechanically capturing the magnetic suture **200**. The suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** thus can be grasped by the grasper arm **126** as the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** is used to pull the magnetic suture **200** through soft tissue of a patient. The grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** are sufficiently strong to resist the frictional drag that results from pulling the magnetic suture **200** through the soft tissue.

(121) As noted above, the grasper arm **126** comprises a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**. Also as noted, the grasper magnet **140** is disposed adjacent the proximal-to-intermediate portion **130** of the grasper arm **126**. The distal portion **132** of the grasper arm **126** has a length and orientation sufficient to allow the suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** to fit between the grasper magnet **140** and the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** when the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**, so that the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** can contact the grasper magnet **140** for magnetic attraction, and when the grasper arm **126** has been returned to the first position **136**, so that the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** can fit within the needle lumen **116** along with the grasper magnet **140** and the grasper arm **126** for mechanical capture. The proximal-to-intermediate portion **130** of the grasper arm **126** adjacent to which the grasper magnet **140** is disposed can be any portion of the grasper arm **126** distal to the proximal end **128** and proximal to the distal portion **132**, so long as sufficient space is provided for a suture magnet **202** to fit between the grasper magnet **140** and the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126**.

(122) In some embodiments, the retriever body **146** and the grasper wire **120** are more flexible than the needle body **108**. This can be advantageous for suture retrieval needles **102** in which one or more portions of the suture retrieval needle **102** are curved, e.g., a suture retrieval needle **102** that includes a curve at or near its distal end **106** but otherwise is straight. Then the retriever body **146** and the grasper wire **120** are preferentially made of a polymeric material, or a metal with a high proportional limit, such as Nitinol, to allow the retriever body **146** and the grasper wire **120** to elastically deform around the curve of the suture retrieval needle **102**.

(123) As noted above, the grasper arm **126** extends from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120**. For a grasper arm **126** that is integral to a grasper wire **120**, the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** is the portion of the grasper wire **120** adjacent the distal end **172** of the retriever body **146**, and the grasper arm **126** begins and extends distally from this distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120**. For a grasper arm **126** that otherwise extends from the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** based on attachment that is direct or indirect, the distal end **124** of the grasper wire **120** is the part of the grasper wire **120** at which the grasper arm **126** is attached.

(124) As shown in FIG. 1 and FIGS. 5-8 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 16 and FIG. 22 for the second embodiment **1002**, and with reference to FIG. 50 for both, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** can include a first grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to a first grasper wire **120** and a second grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to a second grasper wire **120**, with the first and second grasper arms **126** being connected at their distal ends **134**, thereby forming a grasper arm loop **150**. Also as shown, the first and second grasper arms **126** can

comprise an enlarged distal terminus **148** at their distal ends **134**.

(125) This configuration, termed a trap wire **151**, is thus formed from two free ends of wire which meet at a single point at the distal end, i.e., first and second grasper arms **126** extending from first and second grasper wires **120**, respectively, and connected at their distal ends **134**, at which point a large spheroid feature, i.e., an enlarged distal terminus **148**, is located.

(126) The enlarged distal terminus **148** is sized to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138** outside the needle lumen **116**. The enlarged distal terminus **148** also is sized such that when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136** inside the needle lumen **116**, a suture **204** of the magnetic suture **200** can pass by the enlarged distal terminus **148**, but the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** cannot. For example, for a magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** that includes an extra-thin-wall 17 gauge suture retrieval needle **102**, having a nominal inner diameter of 0.050 inches (1.27 mm) and a loop of 3-0 suture, having a mean diameter of 0.0079 to 0.0098 inches (0.20 to 0.25 mm), with a magnetic ferrule having a major outer diameter of 0.040 inches (1.0 mm), the preferred size for this spheroid member is between 0.016 to 0.040 inches (0.41 to 1.0 mm), nominally. More generally, the enlarged distal terminus **148** can have a size corresponding to about 10% to about 90% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**, preferably about 20% to about 80% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**, and more preferably about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. For example, for an enlarged distal terminus **148** corresponding to a spheroid feature, the enlarged distal terminus **148** can have a diameter of about 10% to about 90%, about 20% to about 80%, or about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. Also for example, for an enlarged distal terminus **148** corresponding to an alternative shape, the enlarged distal terminus **148** can have a width transverse to the needle body axis **110** of about 10% to about 90%, about 20% to about 80%, or about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. An enlarged distal terminus **148** within this size range will generally be sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is outside the needle lumen **116**. An enlarged distal terminus **148** within this size range also will generally be sufficiently small to allow a suture **204** of a magnetic suture **200**, even a suture **204** having a relatively large mean diameter, to pass by the enlarged distal terminus **148**, and sufficiently large to prevent the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200**, even a suture magnet **202** of a relatively small size, from passing by the enlarged distal terminus **148**.

(127) Additionally, in this configuration the two strands of wire of the grasper arm loop **150**, i.e., the first grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to the first grasper wire **120** and the second grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to the second grasper wire **120**, flare out before coming back together at the distal ends **134**. This flare is sized so that the width measured across the outer diameter of the wires at this point exceeds the inner diameter of the suture retrieval needle **102**. For example, for an extra-thin-wall 17 gauge suture retrieval needle **102**, the flare is sized so that the width measured across the outer diameter of the wires is greater than 0.050 inches (greater than 1.27 mm). This creates an interference fit between the grasper arm loop **150** and the suture retrieval needle **102**, which results in the wires being squeezed together as they are drawn into the needle lumen **116**. The elastic deformation of the wires generates a reaction force which pushes back against the inner surface of the needle lumen **116**. Because the inner surface of the needle lumen **116** is round, the translation of this force vector by the curved surface acts to push the wires towards the hemisphere of the needle lumen **116**, i.e. the wires are disposed across a center line of the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. This self-centering action helps prevent the spheroid feature from being caught in the crotch of distal hole **114** that is created by the bevel at the sharpened tip of the suture retrieval needle **102**.

(128) The grasper arm loop **150** can have a length and shape such that the grasper arm loop **150** circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a

suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138**. For example, the grasper arm loop **150** can have a length and shape such that the corresponding circumscribed area is sufficiently large to fit both the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** when the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** are in contact at their respective poles.

(129) The grasper arm loop **150** also can be sized such that the grasper arm loop **150** has a thickness, e.g., a mean diameter, sufficiently great to block the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102** when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**. The grasper arm loop **150** can be thinner than the enlarged distal terminus **148** and still block a suture magnet **202** from exiting a needle lumen **116** based on the grasper arm loop **150** being disposed across a center line of the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108** due to an interference fit between the grasper arm loop **150** and the suture retrieval needle **102** as discussed above for the trap wire **151**. Suitable thicknesses, e.g., mean diameters, for the grasper arm loop **150** otherwise can be determined similarly as for the enlarged distal terminus **148**. For example, for a magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** that includes an extra-thin-wall 17 gauge suture retrieval needle **102**, having a nominal inner diameter of 0.050 inches (1.27 mm) and a loop of 3-0 suture, having a mean diameter of 0.0079 to 0.0098 inches (0.20 to 0.25 mm), with a magnetic ferrule having a major outer diameter of 0.040 inches (1.0 mm), the preferred mean diameter for the wire is about 0.0060 inches (0.15 mm). More generally, the grasper arm loop **150** can have a mean diameter, for example, corresponding to about 0.5% to about 10% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**, preferably about 2% to about 4% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**, and more preferably about 2.3% to about 3.5% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. A grasper arm loop **150** within this size range generally will have a thickness, e.g., a mean diameter, sufficiently great to block a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102** when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**.

(130) The preferred material for the first grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to the first grasper wire **120** and the second grasper arm **126** that is integrally attached to the second grasper wire **120** is Nitinol. This is due to the pseudo-elastic nature of Nitinol, which allows wires made from Nitinol to recover their shape after relatively large deformations. The preferred method of manufacture is to hold the two corresponding strands of wire together with the distal ends **134** of their corresponding grasper arms **126** aligned flush, and apply sufficient energy to melt the distal ends **134**. The resulting molten metal at the distal ends **134** thereby pools together, and surface tension pulls the liquid metal into a spheroidal shape. As the metal cools, this shape is naturally maintained, resulting in an autogenous weld between the two strands of wire that is terminated by a spheroidal member.

(131) The trap wire **151** serves as a mechanical plug, creating a blockage within the needle lumen **116** by which the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** cannot pass. This can be accomplished various additional ways too. For example, rather than two grasper arms **126**, a single grasper arm **126** could be employed with an enlarged spheroid end. This provides an advantage of being simpler to manufacture. Alternatively, more than two grasper arms **126** could be employed. This provides an advantage that multiple grasper arms **126** of a smaller cross-section could be employed to obtain an equivalent strength to a single grasper arm **126** of a larger cross-section, but the multiple grasper arms **126** would not intrude as far into the needle lumen **116**, allowing for maximization of the diameter of the grasper magnet **140**. A similar effect could be achieved by using a grasper arm **126** with a non-round profile for the grasper arm **126**. Also alternatively, the plug element does not need to be melt-formed. A separate component may be attached, such as by swaging, or by employing an adhesive. The plug element also does not need to be spheroid, as its shape is not critical to its function. Thus the plug element alternatively could be shaped as, for example, an elongated cylinder, or a pyramid, or a toroid. Also alternatively, the grasper arm **126**

could simply terminate in a pig-tailed coil, forming a basket-like shape.

(132) Accordingly, as shown in FIG. 8 for the first embodiment **1001** and in FIG. 22 for the second embodiment **1002**, with reference to FIGS. 43-47 and FIG. 50 for both embodiments, in some embodiments the grasper wire **120** is a first grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** is a first grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124** and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**; and (b) a second grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**, the second grasper arm **126** extending from the distal end **124** of the second grasper wire **120** and being reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** are connected at their distal ends **134**, thereby forming a grasper arm loop **150**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** further comprises an enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal ends **134** of the first and second grasper arms **126**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** is reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the grasper arm loop **150** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** circumscribes an area sufficiently large, and the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal ends **134** of the first and second grasper arms **126** has a size sufficiently small, to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal ends **134** of the first and second grasper arms **126** has a size sufficiently small to allow a suture **204** of the magnetic suture **200** to pass when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**. In these embodiments, the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal ends **134** of the first and second grasper arms **126** has a size sufficiently large to block the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108** when the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136**. These embodiments are advantageous for allowing use of grasper arms **126** having relatively smaller diameters. In some examples of these embodiments, the size of the enlarged distal terminus **148** is about 10% to about 90%, preferably about 20% to about 80%, more preferably about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. For example, the enlarged distal terminus **148** can have a diameter that is about 10% to about 90%, preferably about 20% to about 80%, more preferably about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. Also in some of these embodiments the mean diameter of the grasper arm loop **150** is about 0.5% to about 10%, preferably about 2% to about 4%, more preferably about 2.3% to about 3.5% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**.

(133) Alternatively or additionally, as shown in FIGS. 64-69, in some embodiments the grasper wire **120** is a first grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** is a first grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124** and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**; and (b) a second grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**, the second grasper arm **126** extending from the distal end **124** of the second grasper wire **120** and being reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** comprise curved portions **152** adjacent their distal ends **134**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** are reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the first and second grasper arms **126** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. The proximal-to-intermediate portions **130** of the first and second grasper arms **126** are substantially parallel to the needle body axis **110** and the curved portions **152** adjacent the distal ends **134** of the first and second grasper arms **126** curve inwardly toward the

needle body axis **110** when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the first position **136**. In these embodiments, at least one of the first or second grasper arms **126** pivots reversibly outwardly from the needle body axis **110** sufficiently far to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the curved portions **152** adjacent the distal ends **134** of the two grasper arms **126** contact the magnetic suture **200** to block the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102** when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the first position **136**. In these embodiments, the two grasper arms **126** can function as a pincer that includes a crotch. In such embodiments, the grasper magnet **140** can advantageously be attached to the crotch of the pincer to attract and hold a magnetic suture **200** in place, thereby easing capture by the pincer. In some examples of these embodiments, both the first and second grasper arms **126** pivot reversibly outwardly from the needle body axis **110** when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the second position **138**. (134) As shown in FIG. 50, in some embodiments the grasper arm **126** further comprises an enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126**. In accordance with these embodiments, the grasper arm **126** is reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the grasper arm **126** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. In accordance with these embodiments, the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** has a size sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138** and to allow a suture **204** of the magnetic suture **200** to pass when the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136**. In these embodiments, the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** has a size sufficiently large to block the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108** when the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136**. In these embodiments, it is the enlarged distal terminus **148** that prevents the magnetic suture **200** from being pulled out of the needle lumen **116**. Accordingly, such a grasper arm **126** only needs to be advanced so far as to free the enlarged distal terminus **148** from the constraint of the suture retrieval needle **102**. If a force is then applied to the magnetic suture **200**, and if the magnetic suture **200** includes a tapered ferrule **206**, then the enlarged distal terminus **148** will ride up the tapered ferrule **206**, which will deflect the grasper arm **126** away from the tapered ferrule **206**, and allow the magnetic suture **200** to pass from the needle lumen **116**. This can be advantageous for suturing at sites within a patient in which space is limited, since it is not necessary for the entire grasper arm **126** to travel beyond the distal end **106** of the suture retrieval needle **102** in order to release the magnetic suture **200**. In some examples of these embodiments, the size of the enlarged distal terminus **148** is about 10% to about 90%, preferably about 20% to about 80%, more preferably about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**. For example, the enlarged distal terminus **148** can have a diameter that is about 10% to about 90%, preferably about 20% to about 80%, more preferably about 30% to about 60% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**.

(135) As shown in FIG. 52 and FIG. 53, in some embodiments the grasper wire **120** is a first grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** is a first grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124** and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**; and (b) a second grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**, the second grasper arm **126** extending from the distal end **124** of the second grasper wire **120** and being reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the first grasper arm **126** further comprises an enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal end **134** of the first grasper arm **126**, and the second grasper arm **126** further comprises an enlarged distal terminus **148** at the distal end **134** of

the second grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** are reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the first and second grasper arms **126** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. In these embodiments, the enlarged distal termini **148** of the first and second grasper arms **126** have sizes sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the second position **138** and to allow a suture **204** of a magnetic suture **200** to pass when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the first position **136**, and sufficiently large to block the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108** when the first and second grasper arms **126** are in the first position **136**. In some of these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises at least one additional grasper wire **120** and at least one additional grasper arm **126** extending distally from the at least one additional grasper wire **120**. These embodiments can be advantageous by allowing for a larger grasper magnet **140** than an equivalent single grasper arm **126** having the same total cross-sectional area. This is because the two or more grasper arms **126** can be positioned radially about the inner surface of a needle lumen **116**, allowing for the cross-sectional area of the grasper arms **126** to be distributed unequally. This leaves more usable space for the grasper magnet **140** to occupy. For example, a dual grasper arm design provides a 12% increase in usable space over a single grasper arm design, while a quadruple grasper arm design provides a 20% increase in usable space over the single grasper arm design. Moreover, the same effect could be achieved by using a wire with a non-round profile for the grasper arm **126**.

(136) Also in some embodiments the grasper wire **120** is a first grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** is a first grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124** and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**; and (b) a second grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a distal end **134**, the second grasper arm **126** extending from the distal end **124** of the second grasper wire **120** and being reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** are connected at their distal ends **134**, thereby forming a grasper arm loop **150**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** is reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the grasper arm loop **150** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** has a thickness sufficiently great to block the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102** when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**. For these embodiments in which the grasper arms **126** do not comprise an enlarged distal terminus **148** at their distal ends **134**, advantages include ease of manufacture and the possibility of using a larger grasper magnet **140**. In some of these embodiments the mean diameter of the grasper arm loop **150** is about 0.5% to about 10%, preferably about 2% to about 4%, more preferably about 2.3% to about 3.5% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**.

(137) Also in some embodiments the grasper wire **120** is a first grasper wire **120** and the grasper arm **126** is a first grasper arm **126**. In these embodiments, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire **120** having a proximal end **122** and a distal end **124** and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body **146**; and (b) a second grasper arm **126** comprising a proximal end **128**, a proximal-to-intermediate portion **130**, a distal portion **132**, and a

distal end **134**, the second grasper arm **126** extending from the distal end **124** of the second grasper wire **120** and being reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the first and second grasper arms **126** are connected at their distal ends **134**, thereby forming a grasper arm loop **150**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** is reversibly moveable between the first position **136** and the second position **138** based on translation of the grasper arm loop **150** from inside of the needle lumen **116** to outside of the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the needle body **108**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** is in an elastically deformed closed state when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**, and the grasper arm loop **150** reversibly expands to an open state when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet **140** and a suture magnet **202** of a magnetic suture **200** attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the second position **138**. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** snares the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** to block the suture magnet **202** from exiting the needle lumen **116** through the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102** when the grasper arm loop **150** is in the first position **136**. In some of these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** is formed of a shape memory alloy. In these embodiments, the grasper arm loop **150** can be a snare, and the snare can include a crotch. In such embodiments, the grasper magnet **140** can advantageously be attached to the crotch of the snare to attract and hold a magnetic suture **200** in place, thereby eliminating the difficult step of threading a suture through the eye of the snare under two-dimensional visualization. In some of these embodiments the mean diameter of the grasper arm loop **150** is about 0.5% to about 10%, preferably about 2% to about 4%, more preferably about 2.3% to about 3.5% of the inner diameter of the needle lumen **116**.

(138) Considering the first embodiment **1001** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further, in some embodiments the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises the hub **119** of the suture retrieval needle **102** and a handle attached to the retriever body **146**. This is advantageous for improving the ergonomics of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** by allowing for single-handed operation. The handle would preferentially include a non-axisymmetric design so as to rotationally fix the handle and the retriever body **146**.

(139) Also in some embodiments the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further comprises a return mechanism, such as a spring. In these embodiments, the retriever body **146** can be attached directly to the handle, so that when the handle is depressed, the retriever body **146** is advanced, which in turn advances the grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** from the needle lumen **116**. When the handle is released, the spring returns the handle to the original position. This returns the grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** to the needle lumen **116**.

(140) The embodiment **1001** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** including a retriever body **146** can be operated as follows.

(141) After a magnetic suture **200** has been deposited inside a patient, the suture retrieval needle **102** is introduced into the patient to gain access to the site of the suture. The retriever body **146** is used to advance the grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** through the needle lumen **116** of the suture retrieval needle **102** until the grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** exit the needle lumen **116**, extending past the distal hole **114** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. The grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** are brought near the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200**, so that the magnetic fields of the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** can interact. The attractive force between the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** pulls the suture magnet **202** towards the grasper magnet **140** and brings them into contact and axial alignment.

(142) Then the retriever body **146** is used to pull the grasper arm **126** and the grasper magnet **140** back inside the needle lumen **116** of the suture retrieval needle **102**. The attractive force between the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** allows the grasper magnet **140** to tow the suture magnet **202**, and the attached suture **204**, along with it. The retriever body **146** is pulled back until

the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** are brought entirely inside the needle lumen **116**. At this point, the magnetic suture **200** cannot escape the suture retrieval needle **102**, because the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** blocks the exit path. The proximal end **128** of the grasper arm **126** is attached to the retriever body **146**, so the grasper arm **126** is not moved by the suture **204**.

(143) Once the magnetic suture **200** has been captured, the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** can be used to pull or push the magnetic suture **200** to a new location. The grasper arm **126** allows the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** to hold the magnetic suture **200** securely, even when the magnetic suture **200** is heavily loaded to the point that the load exceeds the attractive force between grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202**. The grasper arm **126** prevents the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** from being pulled back out of the needle lumen **116**, even when the force applied exceeds the strength of attraction between the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202**.

(144) Once the magnetic suture **200** has been passed to the desired location, the magnetic suture **200** can be released from the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100**. To release the magnetic suture **200**, the retriever body **146** is used to advance the grasper arm **126**, the grasper magnet **140**, and the suture magnet **202** out of the needle lumen **116**, and the suture **204** can then be pulled to disconnect the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202**.

(145) Considering the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** further, as shown in FIGS. **21-43** the second embodiment **1002** further comprises a lock mechanism **300** that can be reversibly engaged to prevent translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** in the first direction and/or the second direction. The lock mechanism **300** can be advantageous for bearing fully a tensile load applied to a magnetic suture **200** in the same direction.

(146) In some embodiments, the lock mechanism **300** that can be reversibly engaged in a first setting that prevents translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** when the distal end **134** of the grasper arm **126** is inside the needle lumen **116** and reversibly engaged in a second setting that prevents translation of the retriever body **146** within the needle lumen **116** when the grasper magnet **140** is outside the needle lumen **116**. In some examples of these embodiments, maintaining the lock mechanism **300** in the first setting or the second setting does not require energy input.

(147) The embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** is such an example. With reference to FIG. **21** and FIG. **22**, the embodiment **1002** includes an advancer assembly comprising the retriever body **146**, a stabilizer tube **302**, an advancer frame **304**, an advancer pad **306**, guide bushings **308**, a return spring **310**, a spring keeper **312**, a cam spring **314**, a drive cam **316**, a lock cam **318**, a hub **119**, and an end effector **320** comprising the trap wire **151** and the magnet wire **160** with the magnet **140** attached. In accordance with these examples, the retriever body **146** passes through a lumen of the stabilizer tube **302**, and is rigidly fixed to the stabilizer tube **302**. The end effector **320** is rigidly fixed to the retriever body **146**. The stabilizer tube **302** passes through ventral rings of the advancer frame **304**, both guide bushings **308**, the spring keeper **312**, the drive cam **316**, and the lock cam **318**, terminating within the body of the hub **119**. The hub **119** and the advancer frame **304** are rigidly fixed to the stabilizer tube **302**, and the advancer pad **306** is rigidly fixed to the advancer frame **304**. The guide bushings **308** are non-rigidly fixed, but are constrained rotationally and laterally by the advancer frame **304**, such that these components move in unison as a single unit. The spring keeper **312** is not fixed within the advancer assembly, but is laterally constrained by a barrel **322** and nose cone **324**, such that the spring keeper **312** has a longitudinal position that is fixed relative to these components. The entire advancer assembly slides within the inner channel of the barrel **322** and nose cone **324**, such that the return spring **310** compresses between the first guide bushing **308** and the spring keeper **312** during this motion.

(148) In accordance with these examples, the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** can be operated as follows.

(149) With reference to FIGS. 23-30 and FIGS. 32-35, initially the advancer assembly of the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** is in an unlocked intermediate position and the grasper arm **126** is in a position intermediate between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. To begin operation, an operator slides the advancer assembly back, with sufficient force to compress the return spring **310**, until the advancer frame **304** engages the maximal boundary of a travel slot **326**. This pulls the end effector **320** into the needle lumen **116** and pushes the lock cam **318** into the relieved space **340** proximal to the locking features of the barrel **322**. With the guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** now freed from the rotational constraint imposed by linear guide channels **330** of the barrel **322**, the force exerted by the (preloaded) cam spring **314** is translated into a rotational movement of the lock cam **318** by way of mating lock cam teeth **332** and drive cam teeth **334** between the lock cam **318** and drive cam **316**. Rotation of the lock cam **318** is halted when crests of the lock cam teeth **332** become nested in valleys between drive cam teeth **334**. At this point, the advancer assembly is in an unlocked retracted position and the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136**. This is designated "Position A." A continual application of external force, e.g., as applied by the operator, sufficient to overcome the elastic strain that has been loaded into the return spring **310**, is required to maintain the advancer assembly in this position.

(150) With reference to FIGS. 23-30 and FIGS. 36-39, to continue operation, the operator releases the advancer assembly, which, in the absence of any external force, is pushed forward by the return spring **310**, which had been compressed in the previous position. As the advancer assembly moves forward, the lock cam teeth **332** slide along the lock ramps **336** of the barrel **322**, resulting in simultaneous linear and rotational translation of the lock cam **318**. This continues until the lock cam teeth **332** meet the lock stops **338** in the barrel **322**, at which point the advancer assembly becomes mechanically locked against any further movement in this direction. At this point, the advancer assembly is in a locked intermediate position and the grasper arm **126** is in a position intermediate between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. This is designated "Position B." The system is in a state of equilibrium in this position, such that no external force is required to maintain this position.

(151) With reference to FIGS. 23-30 and FIGS. 40-43, to continue operation, the operator briefly pulls the advancer assembly back to return the advancer assembly to the previous unlocked retracted position. During this movement, the lock cam **318** once again engages the drive cam **316**, and the lock cam teeth **332** are rotated into the next valley in the crown of the drive cam **316**. When the advancer assembly is released from this position, the return spring **310** pushes the advancer assembly forward, and the lock cam teeth **332** engage the channel ramps **342** in the barrel **322**. The channel ramps **342** guide the teeth **332** and guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** into the linear guide channels **330**. The return spring **310** continues to push the advancer assembly forward until the advancer frame **304** engages the minimum boundary of the travel slot **326**, pushing the end effector **320** out of the cannula. At this point, the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position and the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**. This is designated "Position C." The system is in a state of equilibrium in this position, where no external force is required to maintain this position.

(152) To continue operation, the operator briefly pulls the advancer assembly back. This returns the advancer assembly to the unlocked intermediate position and the grasper arm **126** to the position intermediate between the first position **136** and the second position **138**.

(153) The second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** relies on magnetic attraction to establish a steady-state connection between the magnet-assisted suture passer **100** and a magnetic suture **200** when in Position C as follows. With reference to FIGS. 43-45, the operator moves the advancer assembly forward such that the advancer assembly is in the locked extended position and the grasper arm **126** is in the second position **138**, i.e. Position C. The trap wire **151** and the grasper magnet **140** are brought near the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200**. The trap wire **151** and the grasper magnet **140** do not need to be precisely aligned with the suture

magnet **202**, but only brought near so that the magnetic fields of the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** may interact, allowing the magnetic moments to pull the southern pole of the suture magnet **202** into contact with the northern pole of the grasper magnet **140**, thereby establishing a steady-state connection between the magnet-assisted suture passer **100** and a magnetic suture **200**.

(154) With reference to FIG. **46**, the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** can then accomplish mechanical capture of the magnetic suture **200** by moving from Position C to Position A as follows. After initial attraction, the operator briefly pulls the advancer assembly back, thereby bringing the advancer assembly through the initial unlocked intermediate position and returning the advancer assembly to an unlocked retracted position in which the grasper arm **126** is in the first position **136**, i.e. Position A. The steady-state connection between grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202** allows the grasper magnet **140** to tow the magnetic suture **200** into the needle lumen **116**. The length of the trap wire **151** is designed such that the enlarged distal terminus **148** at the end of the trap wire **151** maintains a distal position relative to the suture magnet **202** inside the cannula. This allows the enlarged distal terminus **148** to act as a plug, creating a physical blockage inside the needle lumen **116** by which the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** cannot pass.

(155) With reference to FIG. **47**, the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** can then accomplish mechanical retention of the magnetic suture **200** in Position B as follows. The operator releases the advancer assembly, which is pushed forward by the return spring **310**, moving the advancer assembly from the unlocked retracted position, which is energetically unfavorable, to the locked intermediate position, i.e. Position B, which is equiposed. The grasper arm **126** is then in a position intermediate between the first position **136** and the second position **138**. While the advancer assembly remains in the locked intermediate position, when the magnetic suture **200** is tensely loaded with a force that exceeds the attractive strength between the grasper magnet **140** and the suture magnet **202**, the suture magnet **202** will be pulled away from grasper magnet **140**, but will be stopped from exiting the needle lumen **116** by the trap wire **151**. The tensile load applied to the magnetic suture **200** is thereby borne by the trap wire **151**, which is translated through the trap wire **151** into the retriever body **146** by way of a rigid joint between these two elements, into the stabilizer tube **302** by way of the joint between these two elements, and into the lock cam **318** by way of the hub **119**, which is also rigidly joined to the stabilizer tube **302**. As the lock cam **318** is fixedly engaged with mechanical locking features of the barrel **322**, this load is ultimately born by the interface between the lock cam **318** and the barrel **322**. The ability of the device to resist tensile loading of the magnetic suture **200** is therefore limited by the tensile strength of these individual elements and the joints between them, as well as the shear strength of the lock cam teeth **332** and the lock stops **338** of the barrel **322**. The material selections and cross-sectional areas of these elements ultimately define a much higher capacity for load bearing than that of the 3-0 suture this system is designed to work with, so that the suture itself becomes the limiting factor in the system. This is preferable to having another part of the system fail before the magnetic suture **200** because the surgeon is not artificially limited as to the amount of tension that can be applied by way of the magnetic suture **200**. Another reason this is preferable is that when the system is overloaded and the magnetic suture **200** breaks, the suture magnet **202** of the magnetic suture **200** remains captured within the needle lumen **116**, allowing for safe retrieval and disposal.

(156) With reference to FIG. **48** and FIG. **49A-C**, the second embodiment **1002** of the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100** also is designed so that the retriever body **146** and stabilizer tube **302** run centrally through all components. The retriever body **146** is designed with an open retriever tube lumen **182** that runs the length of the retriever body **146**. The hub **119** component at the proximal end of the device is structured with an open hub lumen **346** that runs the entire length of the hub **119**. At the distal end, the needle body **108** is also lumenally patent. When assembled, the

retriever tube lumen **182** opens to the hub lumen **346** of the hub **119** at the proximal end, and the needle lumen **116** of the needle body **108** at this distal end, creating a luminal path that extends from end to end through the entire device.

(157) Considering the lock mechanism **300** of the second embodiment **1002** in more detail, this lock mechanism **300** is formed between three components, the lock cam **318**, the drive cam **316**, and the barrel **322**. The guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** and the guide lugs **344** of the drive cam **316** extend from the outer surface of their respective lock cam **318** and drive cam **316** and are disposed 180° apart. The barrel **322** features two guide channels **330**, which are relieved into the inner surface and are also disposed 180° apart. When assembled, the guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** and the guide lugs **344** of the drive cam **316** fit into and slide within the guide channels **330**. The lock cam **318** and drive cam **316** are assembled over the stabilizer tube **302**, distal to the hub **119** and proximal to the advancer frame **304**. The cam spring **314** is placed between the advancer frame **304** and the drive cam **316**. The cam spring **314** is pre-compressed during assembly so that it exerts a continual force upon the drive cam **316**, acting to push the drive cam **316** towards the lock cam **318**. The drive cam **316** features a crown of radially disposed V-shaped teeth **334**. The lock cam **318** features right-triangle shaped teeth **332** with a matching ramp angle to that of the drive cam teeth **334**. The barrel **322** features right angle teeth relieved into the inner surface of the barrel **322**, proximal to the guide channels **330**, also with ramp angles matching the lock and drive cams **316**. The width of the lock cam teeth **332** is wider than the teeth **334** of the drive cam **316**, so that the lock cam teeth **332** extend beyond the outer diameter of the drive cam teeth **334**. The arrangement of teeth **332** on the lock cam **318** is such that when the lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** and the lugs **344** of the drive cam **316** are aligned, the apexes of the lock cam teeth **332** are slightly aft of the apexes of the nearest drive cam teeth **334**. The arrangement of the barrel teeth is such that with the lock cam teeth **332** nested in the valley between drive cam teeth **334**, the apexes of the lock cam teeth **332** sit slightly aft to the apex of the barrel teeth **334**.

(158) Operationally, the guide lugs **344** of the drive cam **316** remain within the guide channel **330** along all points of linear travel by the sliding assembly. As such, the drive cam **316** is always constrained against rotation about the neutral axis. The lock cam **318** is constrained in the same manner while the guide lugs **328** are positioned within the guide channel **330**, but the lock cam **318** fully enters the relieved space **340** created by the barrel teeth **334** at the maximal extent of travel, i.e. Position A, which frees the guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** from guide channel **330**, allowing the lock cam **318** to rotate about the neutral axis. When the guide lugs **328** of the lock cam **318** are freed from the constraints of the guide channel **330**, the force exerted by the cam spring **314** drives the drive cam **316** towards the lock cam **318**. The ramp angle of the mating lock cam teeth **332** and drive cam teeth **334** causes the lock cam **318** to slide along the drive cam tooth **334** towards the valley between drive cam teeth **334**. As the drive cam **316** is rotationally constrained, but the lock cam **318** is not, this movement results in a counter-clockwise rotation of the lock cam **318** (approximately 45°). From this position, the sliding components of the assembly are moved back in the opposite direction, toward Position C, which causes the lock cam teeth **332** to make contact with the lock ramps **336** of the barrel **322**. Sliding contact of the lock cam teeth **332** with the lock ramps **336** causes a further counterclockwise rotation of the lock cam **318**, until the teeth **332** make contact with the lock stops **338** (approximately 45°). This is the locked position. In this position, further movement from Position A to Position C is not possible. The lock is released by the sliding the moving assembly back to Position A, which drives the lock cam teeth **332** beyond the extends of the lock stops **338**, at which point the lock cam **318** is rotationally driven further clockwise by the drive cam teeth **334**. From this position, the sliding assembly can be driven to Position C. As the lock cam **318** advances linearly towards Position C, the lock cam teeth **332** contact the channel ramps **342** in the barrel **322**, and the sliding contact results in further counterclockwise rotation of the lock cam **318**. At the lower apex of the channel ramps **342** are the guide channels **330**, so that as the lock cam teeth **332** slide along the channel ramps **342** the guide

lugs **328** are guided into the guide channels **330**, allowing the entire sliding assembly to move towards Position C. The rotational nature of this cycle is such that one lock/unlock cycle results in 180° translation of the lock cam **318**, and two complete lock/unlock cycles returns the components to their original position (360° rotation). This allows for the lock/unlock cycle to be repeated indefinitely.

(159) As will be appreciated, other lock mechanisms can also be used with the magnet-assisted suture grasper **100**. For example, the lock mechanism **300** can include a simple lever arm molded into a hub **119** of the suture retrieval needle **102** and serrations on the outer surface of a retriever body **146** such that the lever arm can engage with the serrations to lock the retriever body **146**, and thus the grasper wire **120**, against translation relative to the suture retrieval needle **102**. Other suitable lock mechanisms **300** also can be used.

(160) With reference to FIGS. **54-58**, a magnetic suture loop **400** also is disclosed. The magnetic suture loop **400** comprises a suture magnet **402** and a bifurcated suture **404** extending from the suture magnet **402** and forming a suture loop **406**.

(161) The magnetic suture loop **400** can be made similarly as described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667, as discussed above. Thus, in some embodiments the magnetic suture loop **400** further comprises a ferrule **408** with a tapered region **410** in which the bifurcated suture **404** is provided knotted and secured with an adhesive and a straight region **412** in which the suture magnet **402** is provided.

(162) The magnetic suture loop **400** is advantageous for providing a means of snaring a second suture, for the purpose of pulling the second suture through the suture loop **406** created by the first suture. A surgeon can accomplish this as follows. The magnetic suture loop **400** is first passed through a tissue of a patient, so that the magnetic suture loop **400** has an entrance point and an exit point from the patient. The entrance point and exit points can be separate points or the same point. A strand of a second suture is then passed through the suture loop **406** of the magnetic suture loop **400**. The magnetic suture loop **400** is then pulled through the tissue from the opposite end. As the magnetic suture loop **400** is pulled through the entrance point of the tissue, the suture loop **406** is closed around the second suture by the tissue, effectively snaring the second suture. This snaring action allows the magnetic suture loop to pull the second suture through the tissue and out the exit point, so that the second suture now occupies the path that was previously occupied by the magnetic suture loop **400**. This is advantageous because it allows limiting permutations of suture size, material, and construction, without restricting choice as to the type of suture that will be used. For example, if a surgeon wishes to use a different style of suture than the magnetic suture loop **400**, the surgeon can use the magnetic suture loop **400** to establish the path, and then use the technique described above to quickly and easily exchange the magnetic suture loop **400** for a different second suture.

(163) With reference to FIGS. **59-63**, a preloaded magnetic suture cartridge **500** also is disclosed. The preloaded magnetic suture cartridge **500** comprises a magnetic suture loop **400** and a cartridge tube **502**. The magnetic suture loop **400** can be as described above. The cartridge tube **502** comprises a cartridge tube proximal opening **504**, a cartridge tube distal opening **506**, and a cartridge tube lumen **508** therebetween.

(164) The magnetic suture loop **400** can be preloaded into the cartridge tube **502** during manufacture, such that the suture loop **406** of the magnetic suture loop **400** traverses the cartridge tube lumen **508**, which is sized such that the suture loop **406** is free to enter the cartridge tube lumen **508** but the suture magnet **402** of the suture loop **406** does not enter the cartridge tube lumen **508**, so that the suture loop **406** can freely pass through the cartridge tube lumen **508** in one direction but is captured in the opposite direction. The wall thickness of the cartridge tube **502** and the modulus of the material used in its construction are such that the cartridge tube **502** has greater column strength than the suture loop **406**, allowing the preloaded magnetic suture cartridge **500**, including the magnetic suture loop **400**, to be easily inserted into and advanced through a cannula

by pushing from one end.

(165) This is advantageous because the suture loop **406** itself does not have sufficient column strength to allow the suture loop **406** to be pushed through a cannula from one end. The cartridge tube **502** therefore facilitates advancing the suture loop **406** through a cannula and into the intracorporeal working space. The cannula and the cartridge tube **502** can then be removed, leaving only the suture loop **406** behind. Alternatively, the cannula can be removed and the cartridge tube **502** with captured suture loop **406** can be left behind. Leaving the cartridge tube **502** in this manner may provide some benefit during the procedure because the stiffness of the cartridge tube **502** provides the operator with a means for directionally manipulating the suture magnet **402** of the magnetic suture loop **400** at the distal end of the suture loop **406** from outside the body. To this effect, a curve can be added to the distal end of the cartridge tube **502**, which further enhances the operator's ability to directionally manipulate the suture magnet **402** of the magnetic suture loop **400** within the intracorporeal space.

(166) A system for passing a magnetic suture also is disclosed. The system comprises the magnet-assisted suture grasper as described above. The system also comprises a magnetic suture comprising a suture magnet and a suture extending from the suture magnet as described above.

(167) Another system for passing a magnetic suture also is disclosed. The system comprises the magnet-assisted suture grasper as described above. The system also comprises a magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet and a bifurcated suture extending from the suture magnet and forming a suture loop as described above.

(168) In some embodiments, this system further comprises a cartridge tube as described above. The cartridge tube comprises a cartridge tube proximal opening, a cartridge tube distal opening, and a cartridge tube lumen therebetween. The suture loop traverses the cartridge tube lumen based on having been inserted through the cartridge tube distal opening. The suture magnet is disposed outside of the cartridge tube lumen adjacent the cartridge tube distal opening.

(169) The magnet-assisted suture grasper disclosed herein can be used for passing a magnetic suture that includes a suture magnet at an end of the suture. Such a magnetic suture can be made, for example, as described in U.S. Pub. No. 2021/0059667. The magnet-assisted suture grasper disclosed herein also can be used for passing a magnetic suture that is magnetic based on including a magnetic metal within the suture.

(170) The magnet-assisted suture grasper disclosed herein may be useful in procedures including, among others: (1) Inguinal hernia repair through high ligation of the patent processus vaginalis as described above; (2) Laparoscopic port closure (typical suture size 2-0 and larger); (3) Microsurgery (typical suture size 7-0 and smaller); (4) General surgery (typical suture size 2-0 to 0); and (5) Orthopedic surgery (typical suture size 0 and larger).

(171) The magnet-assisted suture grasper also may be modified for use in ultrasound-guided surgical techniques. The magnet-assisted suture grasper would be modified by making the distal end of the suture retrieval needle echogenic. This could be done, for example, by applying an echogenic treatment at the distal tip of the suture retrieval needle. The modified magnet-assisted suture grasper would then be used with a hypodermic needle for introducing a suture wherein the hypodermic needle also is echogenic at its distal end. Optionally the magnets of the magnet-assisted suture grasper and the magnetic suture and/or the ferrules that attach the magnets to the wire of the magnet-assisted suture grasper and to the suture also may be made echogenic, for example by applying an echogenic treatment to the magnets and/or the ferrules.

(172) Use of the modified magnet-assisted suture grasper in ultrasound-guided surgical techniques could result in reductions in operative time and complexity by eliminating the need for suction equipment. Suction equipment currently is needed to pass the suture through the needle.

(173) The modified magnet-assisted suture grasper also may allow an alternative technique whereby the suture is dropped off and retrieved from inside the abdominal cavity. This would allow the repair to be completed entirely through a single needle-access point, which would provide

improved cosmesis, and could result in less post-operative pain. Under the current laparoscopic approach (termed the PEAR/PIRS technique), the needle is introduced through the skin and directed medial around the defect, exiting inferior to the defect through the peritoneum into the abdominal cavity. Drop-off and retrieval of the suture occurs in this space inside the abdominal cavity. This is not currently possible under ultrasonic guidance because the suture is not echogenic, so the surgeon would have to retrieve the suture from inside the abdominal cavity completely blind. This would be nearly impossible with the current state of suture passer technology (i.e., snares, graspers, etc.). In contrast, the modified magnet-assisted suture grasper may allow this to work, especially if the needle points and ferrules are echogenic.

(174) The mechanical grasper arm technology described herein could be integrated into the magnetic U-stitch suturing device disclosed in U.S. Pat. No. 10,245,021 to provide a more secure means of holding a magnetic suture during retrieval. In addition, this could allow the operation of the device to be changed such that the suture does not need to be pulled completely out of the body through the second cannula, but could simply be captured, and then the whole device removed, pulling the suture through the tissue directly. This should allow the magnetic U-stitch suturing device to be used to place multiple sutures with a single device.

(175) In addition, the magnet-assisted suture grasper described herein could be integrated as end-of-arm tooling for robot-assisted surgery or into the end of an endoscope for direct manipulation of a suture with the endoscope.

(176) Although the magnet-assisted suture grasper is described for grasping a magnetic suture, the magnet-assisted suture grasper also can be used for grasping sutures that include ferromagnetic elements that are attracted by magnets without necessarily including a suture magnet.

(177) While this invention has been described in conjunction with the specific embodiments outlined above, it is evident that many alternatives, modifications and variations will be apparent to those skilled in the art. Accordingly, the preferred embodiments of the invention as set forth above are intended to be illustrative, not limiting. Various changes may be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention.

CLAUSES

(178) 1. A magnet-assisted suture grasper for grasping a magnetic suture comprising: (a) a suture retrieval needle comprising a proximal end, a distal end, and a needle body extending therebetween, the needle body defining a needle body axis between the proximal and distal ends of the suture retrieval needle, the needle body having a proximal hole, a distal hole, and a needle lumen extending therebetween along the needle body axis; (b) a retriever body disposed within the needle lumen and translatable therein along the needle body axis; (c) a grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; (d) a grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the grasper arm extending from the distal end of the grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between a first position and a second position; and (e) a grasper magnet being disposed adjacent the proximal-to-intermediate portion of the grasper arm, the magnet-assisted suture grasper sequestering the grasper magnet within the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the first position and exposing the grasper magnet from the needle lumen when the grasper arm is in the second position, wherein: the distal end of the grasper arm extends further distally than the grasper magnet, translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the first position to the second position, thereby exposing the grasper magnet and allowing contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto, and translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in a second direction opposite the first direction along the needle body axis causes the grasper arm to move from the second position to the first position, thereby sequestering the grasper magnet and grasping the magnetic suture within the needle lumen.

(179) 2. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 1, wherein the suture retrieval

needle is a hypodermic needle.

(180) 3. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 1 or 2, wherein the suture retrieval needle is straight, the needle body axis thereby being straight.

(181) 4. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 1 or 2, wherein the suture retrieval needle is curved, the needle body axis thereby being curved.

(182) 5. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 4, wherein the suture retrieval needle has a sharp tip.

(183) 6. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 5, wherein the suture retrieval needle further comprises a hub.

(184) 7. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 6, wherein the retriever body and the grasper wire are more flexible than the needle body.

(185) 8. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 7, wherein: the retriever body comprises a proximal end, a distal end, and a retriever tube extending therebetween, the retriever tube defining a retriever tube axis between the proximal and distal ends of the retriever body, the retriever tube having a proximal hole, a distal hole, and a retriever tube lumen extending therebetween along the retriever tube axis; and the proximal hole of the retriever tube is in fluid communication with the distal hole of the needle body through the retriever tube lumen and the needle lumen.

(186) 9. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 8, wherein the grasper arm is integral to the grasper wire.

(187) 10. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 9, further comprising a magnet wire having a proximal end and a distal end, wherein the proximal end of the magnet wire is fixedly disposed within the retriever body and the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the distal end of the magnet wire, either directly or indirectly.

(188) 11. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 10, wherein the magnet wire further comprises a magnet wire distal terminus at the distal end of the magnet wire, the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises a ferrule attached to the magnet wire distal terminus, and the grasper magnet is attached to the ferrule.

(189) 12. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 9, wherein the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the grasper arm, either directly or indirectly.

(190) 13. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 9, wherein the grasper magnet is fixedly attached to the grasper wire, either directly or indirectly.

(191) 14. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper arm further comprises an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm; the grasper arm is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the grasper arm has a size sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm is in the second position and to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the grasper arm is in the first position, and sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the grasper arm is in the first position.

(192) 15. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first grasper arm further comprises an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the first grasper arm; the second grasper arm further

comprises an enlarged distal terminus at the distal end of the second grasper arm; the first and second grasper arms are reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the first and second grasper arms from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; and the enlarged distal termini of the first and second grasper arms have sizes sufficiently small to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms are in the second position and to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position, and sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position.

(193) 16. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 15, further comprising at least one additional grasper wire and at least one additional grasper arm extending distally from the at least one additional grasper wire.

(194) 17. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; and the grasper arm loop has a thickness sufficiently great to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(195) 18. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the first and second grasper arms further comprise an enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large, and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently small, to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently small to allow a suture of the magnetic suture to pass when the grasper arm loop is in the first position; and the enlarged distal terminus at the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms has a size sufficiently large to block the suture magnet of the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(196) 19. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms are connected at their distal ends, thereby forming a grasper arm loop; the grasper arm loop is reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the grasper arm loop from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the grasper arm loop is in an elastically deformed closed state when the grasper arm loop is in the first position; the grasper arm loop reversibly expands to an open state when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; the grasper arm loop circumscribes an area sufficiently large to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a suture magnet of a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the grasper arm loop is in the second position; and the grasper arm loop snares the suture magnet of the magnetic suture to block the suture magnet from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the grasper arm loop is in the first position.

(197) 20. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 19, wherein the grasper arm loop is formed of a shape memory alloy.

(198) 21. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 13, wherein: the grasper wire is a first grasper wire; the grasper arm is a first grasper arm; the magnet-assisted suture grasper further comprises: (a) a second grasper wire having a proximal end and a distal end and being fixedly disposed within the retriever body; and (b) a second grasper arm comprising a proximal end, a proximal-to-intermediate portion, a distal portion, and a distal end, the second grasper arm extending from the distal end of the second grasper wire and being reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position; the first and second grasper arms comprise curved portions adjacent their distal ends; the first and second grasper arms are reversibly moveable between the first position and the second position based on translation of the first and second grasper arms from inside of the needle lumen to outside of the needle lumen through the distal hole of the needle body; the proximal-to-intermediate portions of the first and second grasper arms are substantially parallel to the needle body axis and the curved portions adjacent the distal ends of the first and second grasper arms curve inwardly toward the needle body axis when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position; at least one of the first or second grasper arms pivots reversibly outwardly from the needle body axis sufficiently far to allow contact between the grasper magnet and a magnetic suture attracted thereto when the first and second grasper arms are in the second position; and the curved portions adjacent the distal ends of the two grasper arms contact the magnetic suture to block the magnetic suture from exiting the needle lumen through the distal hole of the suture retrieval needle when the first and second grasper arms are in the first position.

(199) 22. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to any one of clauses 1 to 21, further comprising a lock mechanism that can be reversibly engaged to prevent translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen in the first direction and/or the second direction.

(200) 23. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 22, wherein the lock mechanism can be reversibly engaged in a first setting that prevents translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen when the distal end of the grasper arm is inside the needle lumen and reversibly engaged in a second setting that prevents translation of the retriever body within the needle lumen when the grasper magnet is outside of the needle lumen.

(201) 24. The magnet-assisted suture grasper according to clause 23, wherein maintaining the lock mechanism in the first setting or the second setting does not require energy input.

(202) 25. A system for passing a magnetic suture comprising: the magnet-assisted suture grasper of any one of clauses 1-24; and a magnetic suture comprising a suture magnet and a suture extending from the suture magnet.

(203) 26. A system for passing a magnetic suture comprising: the magnet-assisted suture grasper of any one of clauses 1-24; and a magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet and a bifurcated suture extending from the suture magnet and forming a suture loop.

(204) 27. The system according to clause 26, further comprising a cartridge tube, wherein: the cartridge tube comprises a cartridge tube proximal opening, a cartridge tube distal opening, and a cartridge tube lumen therebetween; the suture loop traverses the cartridge tube lumen based on having been inserted through the cartridge tube distal opening; and the suture magnet is disposed outside of the cartridge tube lumen adjacent the cartridge tube distal opening.

Claims

1. A magnetic suture loop comprising a suture magnet, a bifurcated suture, and a cartridge tube, wherein: the bifurcated suture extends from the suture magnet and forms a suture loop; the cartridge tube comprises a cartridge tube proximal end, a cartridge tube distal end, and a cartridge tube wall extending therebetween; the cartridge tube has a cartridge tube proximal opening at the cartridge tube proximal end, a cartridge tube distal opening at the cartridge tube distal end, and a cartridge tube lumen extending from the cartridge tube proximal opening to the cartridge tube distal opening; the suture loop traverses the cartridge tube lumen based on having been inserted through the cartridge tube distal opening; and the suture magnet is disposed outside of the cartridge tube lumen adjacent the cartridge tube distal opening.
 2. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the suture magnet is a dipole magnet.
 3. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the bifurcated suture has a tensile strength of at least 0.96 kgf.
 4. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 3, wherein the bifurcated suture has a tensile strength of 1.5 to 2.0 kgf.
 5. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the bifurcated suture has a mean diameter of at least the mean diameter of a 7-0 suture.
 6. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 5, wherein the bifurcated suture is one or more of a 7-0 suture, a 3-0 suture, a 2-0 suture, or a 0 suture.
 7. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the bifurcated suture further comprises a ferrule comprising (i) a tapered region in which the bifurcated suture is secured and (ii) a straight region in which the suture magnet is provided.
 8. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the cartridge tube lumen is sized such that the suture loop of the bifurcated suture is free to enter the cartridge tube lumen but the suture magnet cannot enter the cartridge tube lumen, thereby allowing the suture loop of the bifurcated suture to freely pass through the cartridge tube lumen in one direction but to be captured in the opposite direction.
 9. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the cartridge tube wall has a wall thickness and a modulus providing the cartridge tube with a greater column strength than the suture loop of the bifurcated suture.
 10. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the cartridge tube distal end is straight.
 11. The magnetic suture loop according to claim 1, wherein the cartridge tube distal end is curved.
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